



Location Indicator Plan

Chapter 3

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3.0 Location Indicator Plan

PRINCIPLES FOR THE LOCATION INDICATOR SYSTEM

Even with great strides in technology the first sixty minutes after an accident remain the most critical to saving lives. Therefore the best tool to help save lives is the ability to find and treat an injured person quickly. The greatest challenge for a successful emergency response is the development of a location indicator system.

To develop an effective system it is crucial to understand how emergency personnel operate coupled with how people react in crisis situations. The system must be easy to use. It must narrow the search area as accurately as possible. It is also necessary to study existing numbering systems (trail and river mile markers, etc.) to determine whether they can be used as part of an effective location indicator system.

The following principles for the location indicator system, or “help numbers,” were developed after discussions with area stakeholders and emergency personnel:

- **Location indicator system should be reduced to the simplest identifier and applied consistently in both land and water environments.**

A person reporting an emergency should be able to give a minimum amount of information that quickly and accurately locates them within the 130-mile corridor. The system should be simple enough for a young child or person with limited English to use.

- **There should not be any duplication of location indicators along the corridor, similar to setting up a street address.**

The first option was to use the existing land trail mile markers as the help numbers. This seemed logical as the number already tells users how far they have traveled along a trail. However there were several difficulties with using these markers. First, the Schuylkill River Trail system is not complete and there is no way to predict where and how long future trails might be. As new trails come on line, older trails would need to be renumbered to maintain a continuous sequence. This re-numbering would mean replacing or updating existing markers, databases, trail head signs, maps and brochures.

Second, the water trail is longer than the land trails so there would have to be different sequential mile numbers for each side of the river, in addition to the river mile number.

Third, to identify their location a user would need to know information (in addition to the mile number) such as their side of the river, county, township, and possibly the trail name. The more modifiers that are added to the system, the greater the chance for error and delay.

- **Emergency locator indicators should coordinate road access, foot trail access and river access points.**
- **The system should provide for locations along the river’s tributaries.**



3.0 Location Indicator Plan

THE HELP NUMBER

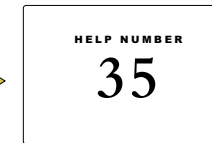
The numbers established by the River Mile System, recognized and published by the Delaware River Basin Commission, have been chosen for the Help Numbers on the Schuylkill River. The river mile marker numbers are a continuous system, effective because they align at designated coordinates across the river and its tributaries.

Using this number as the help number allows a 911 operator to quickly locate someone in distress. For example, when the 911 operator keys in the Help Number, access roads, boat launches, local geographic information and corresponding trail points on both sides of the river would come up. This information can be quickly relayed to the appropriate response team. The database will allow the county, township, park and the appropriate response team(s) to be given accurate location information.

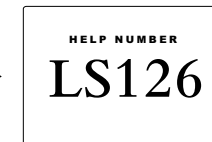
Boaters traveling downstream communicate directions when moving a craft towards the right or left banks by using the terms *river right* and *river left*. Since this system is an established part of river vocabulary, it makes sense to add these terms to clarify the correct side of the river. Initials (such as LS for “Little Schuylkill”) can also be added to distinguish between the river and its tributaries.

And finally, distinct geometries and colors (the examples use diamond/ yellow for Left Bank and ellipse/red for Right Bank) are recommended as an additional way to reinforce and distinguish locations.

A sign plaque or decal carrying the help number can be attached to poles, signs or surfaces to create a continuous emergency response system throughout the trail system.



Differentiate left and right banks with memorable geometric shapes and colors.



An alpha modifier helps distinguish between tributaries feeding into the Schuylkill River.

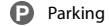
By establishing a unique sign design and adding the Schuylkill River Heritage Area wordmark to these plaques, the identity of the Heritage Area can be raised within the community.



3.0 Location Indicator Plan

Schuylkill River Water & Land Trail Location Indicator Diagram 1

LEGEND



Parking

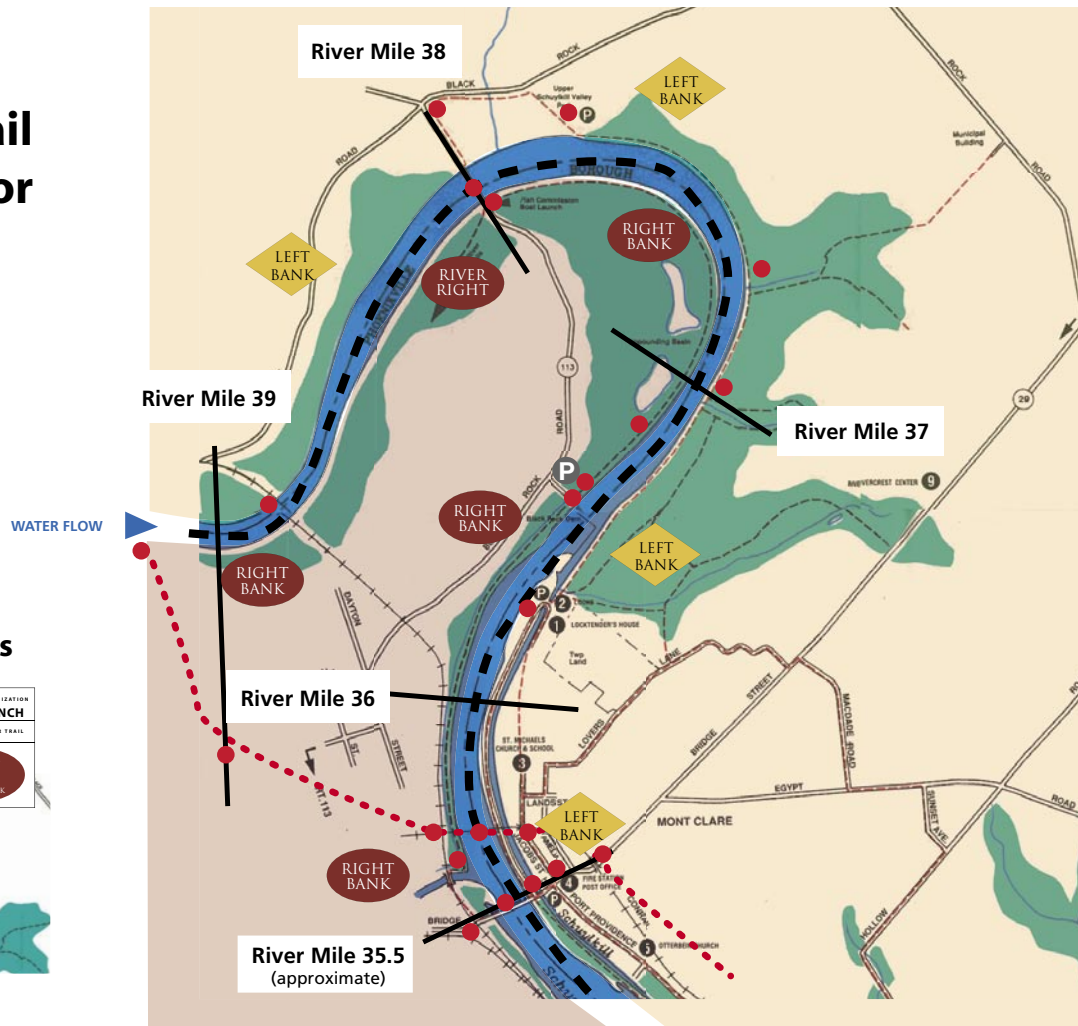
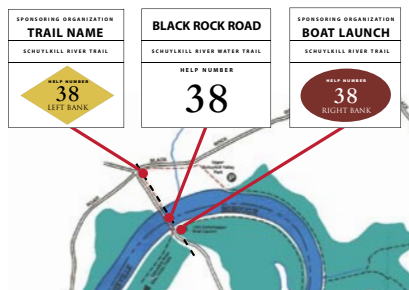
..... Schuylkill River Land Trail

— Schuylkill River Water Trail

- - - Trails

● Signs with Location Indicator Information

The Help Number Address

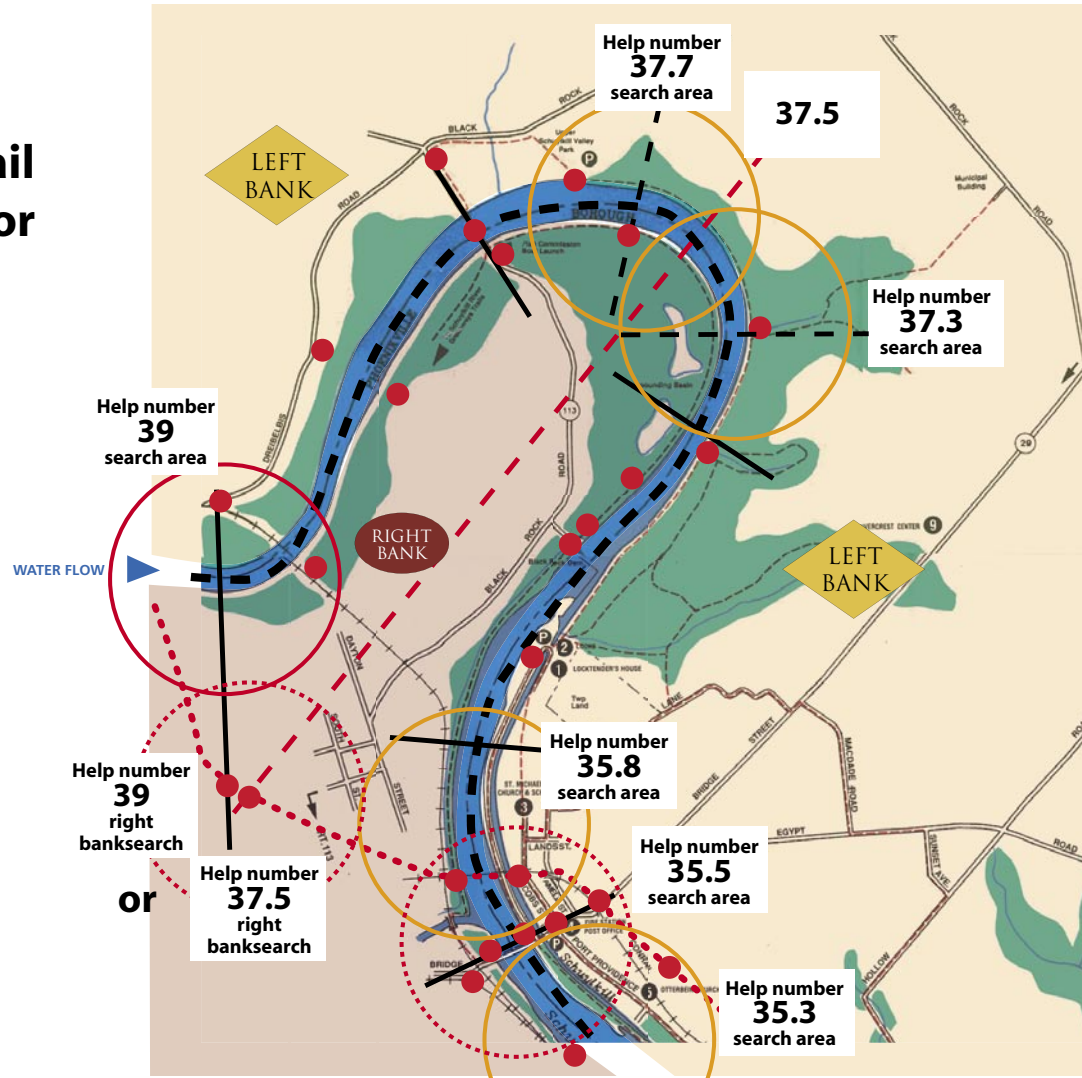




3.0 Location Indicator Plan

Schuylkill River Water & Land Trail Location Indicator Diagram 2

- LEGEND**
- Parking
 - Schuylkill River Land Trail
 - Schuylkill River Water Trail
 - Trails
 - Signs with Location Indicator Information

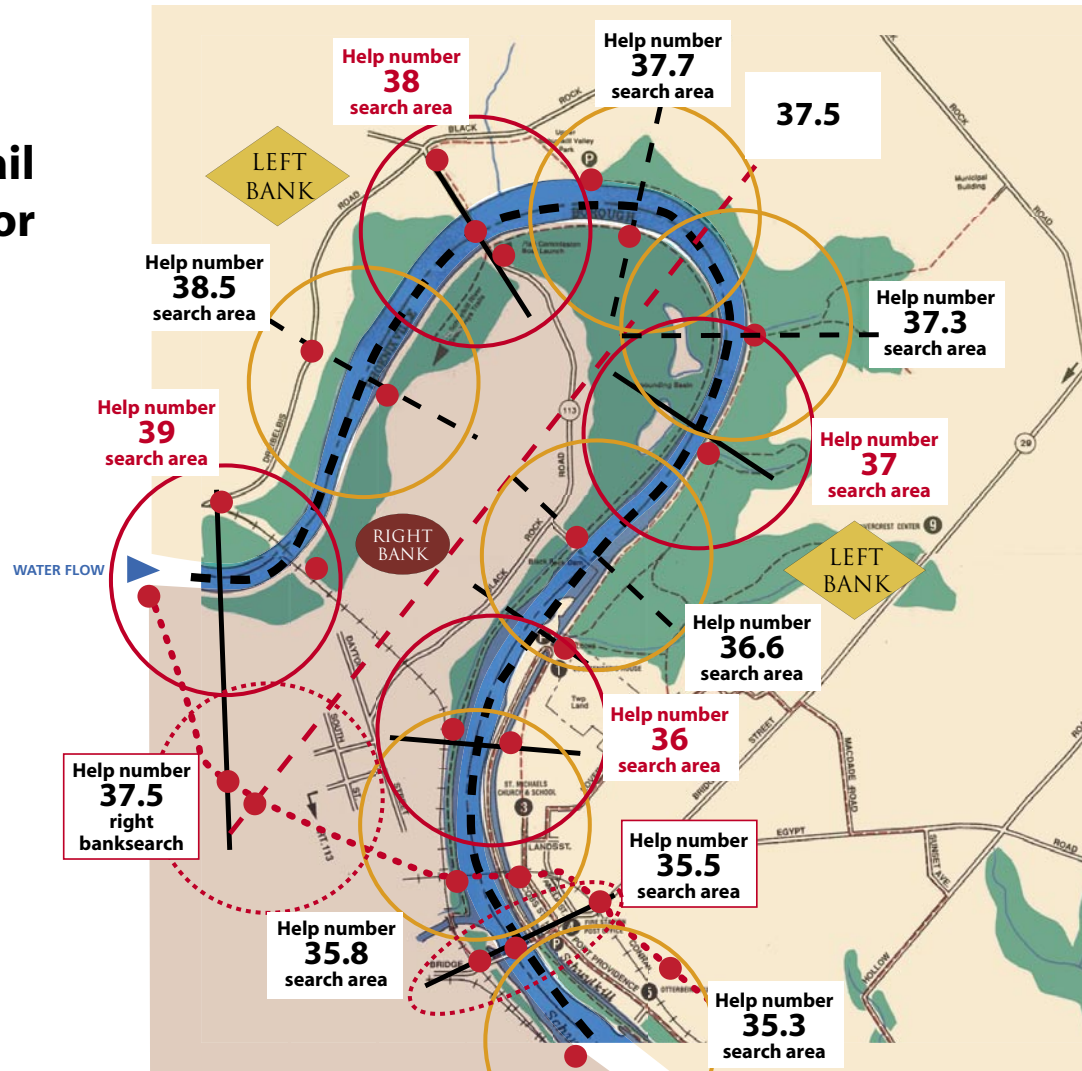




3.0 Location Indicator Plan

Schuylkill River Water & Land Trail Location Indicator Diagram 3

- LEGEND**
- Parking
 - Schuylkill River Land Trail
 - Schuylkill River Water Trail
 - Trails
 - Signs with Location Indicator Information





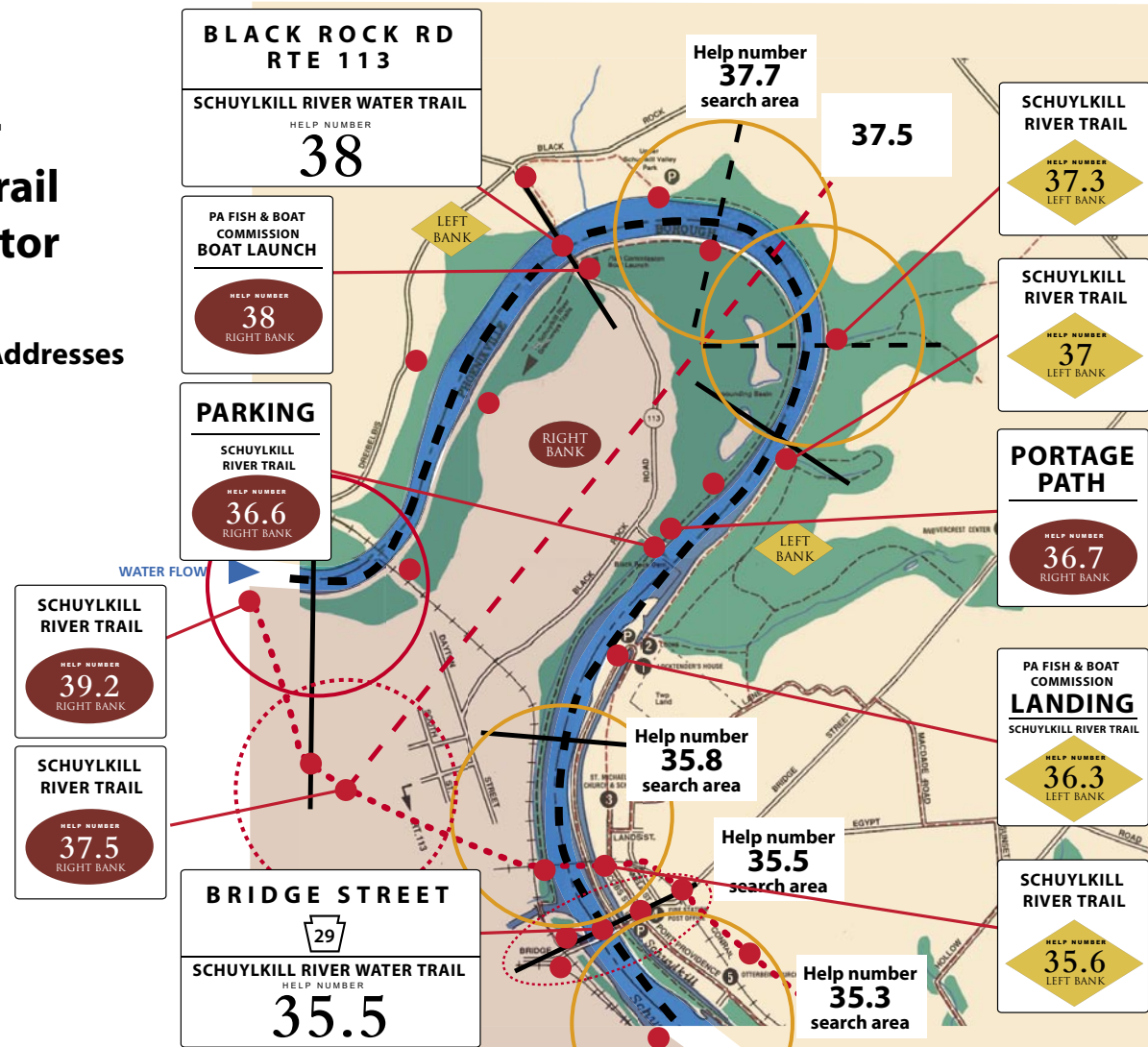
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Schuylkill River Water & Land Trail Location Indicator Diagram 4

Sample Help Number Addresses

LEGEND

- Parking
- Schuylkill River Land Trail
- Schuylkill River Water Trail
- Trails
- Signs with Location Indicator Information





3.0 Location Indicator Plan

IMPLEMENTING THE PLAN

Create committee to identify and plot Help Numbers

- include representatives from county emergency management agencies, parks and recreation personnel, Schuylkill River Heritage Area associations and any other interested parties
- meet on regular basis to review system or identify issues

Create database of Help Numbers with:

- GIS information
- location information such as county, park and sponsoring organization names
- geographical points of interest
- emergency access points
- prioritized emergency response teams
- alerts to hazards
- nearest emergency medical facilities

Produce maps with Help Number locations for emergency response teams

- make available on WEB
- update maps and literature (river guide)

Audit existing signs

- map and key existing sign locations
- create message schedule data base: note message, condition, and visibility

Develop sign guidelines

- Design sign types, typical messages and more specific location criteria and performance recommendations
- develop maintenance plan

Develop master message and sign location plan

- determine sign types, messages and placement to create a cohesive information and emergency response system

Implementation

- add help numbers to existing signs
- fabricate and install new signs

Train, market, promote and educate on using the Help Number

- train emergency personnel
- produce literature, targeting local users groups
- make literature available to local responder groups i.e. fire and police
- approach the all County Emergency Management Agency to have the literature and post it on their web sites
- do an initial press release
- work with out-fitter groups to educate the public through literature, posters and maps
- work with schools to promote the Help Number education
- place literature with tourism boards

Maintenance

- conduct yearly audit of trail signs
- replace damaged or missing signs
- make emergency signs available for use throughout the heritage trail area